spending elsewhere the money given to him for a book, Maa had treated him the same way. His pocket allowance was cut off and he was shown no mercy. *If you do something wrong, intentionally or unintentionally, don't try to hide it with a lie. If you tell the truth, we will not get mad at you, we will always help you,* Maa had told him back then. Later, when I showed my homework notebook to Ms Meenakshi and confessed to her, she made the entire class applaud. She was happy that I had displayed such determination and integrity. Honestly, it filled me with pride; it was an incident I would remind myself of often in future. When I reached home that afternoon, I waited for Maa. When she finally returned from school, I ran straight to her and hugged her. There were tears in her eyes and in mine. I had learnt my lesson. The upcoming Friday, we didn't have to go to the officers' mess to watch our favourite sitcom. Maa bought a television for us from her savings —a Weston CRT colour television. Her children had earned it, she would say. Besides, having a television at home saved a lot of time that was wasted travelling to the mess. She wanted us to dedicate the time to our studies, to subjects that needed attention. I dedicated it to social science. When Papaji came home the next week, Maa filled him in on everything he had missed. He was amazed and proud at the fact that I hadn't broken down under pressure, even at such a young age. 'You must know, Gunju, your parents work really hard to make sure you and Anshu get everything,' Papaji said to me one night, when he came to my room to wish me goodnight after dinner. 'Maa has sacrificed her own wants to fulfil her children's needs. Sacrifice and hard work reap honest and great results. Maa and I believe you and Anshu will make us proud one day. To be able to do so, sometimes you will have to get out of your comfort zone and accept challenges. And remember, never seek shortcuts, never seek privilege, never do anything dishonourable. You must earn everything you get. There's a different taste to it, a taste of satisfaction.' Then he kissed me goodnight on my forehead and left. But I spent the rest of the night thinking about what Papaji had told me.

* * *